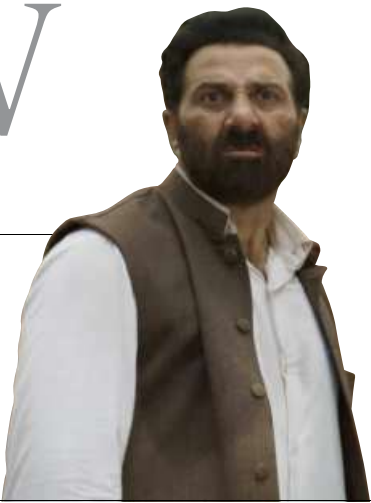


fridayReview

THE HINDU

Here comes the One G
N. Guruprasad gives the traditional clay ghatam a wooden makeover **p2**

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WOUNDS, BOND AND THE BORDER
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Subha I Rao

In a land as vast and diverse as pre-Independence India, and long before the telecommunication revolution, the flame of patriotism was lit by the written, spoken and sung word. Poets used their pens as weapons of resistance and inspired people to put the Nation before self. It was through these literary works that the stories of courage and sacrifice spread across the country – the songs and poems spoke about the crushing isolation of dark prison cells and the brutalities of the British. Sometime in the 1970s and 1980s, growing up in the suburbs of a tier-two city in Tamil Nadu, about 50 km from Tirupur, where the 27-year-old Kumaran, famously revered as ‘Kodi Kaatha Kumaran’, chose death over letting the flag fall, and near Coimbatore, where freedom fighter V.O. Chidambaram Pillai was imprisoned, our connect to the freedom struggle was through stories narrated by elders and the patriotic songs aired on Akashvani and Vividh Bharati.

Freedom notes

There would be a smattering of Tamil songs, and a few Hindi favourites – ‘Achamillai acham enbadhillaye’ (there is simply no fear), ‘Vande maataram enbom’ (let’s all chant Vande Mataram), ‘Vaazhga nee emmaan’ (may you live long, a song about how Mahatma Gandhi helped raise a country from the depths of despair), ‘Thaneer vitto valarthom sarvesa’ (did we water the plant called independence? No, we raised it with our tears), and the ubiquitous ‘Saare jahaan se accha’ and ‘Nanna munna rahee hoon’ (made popular by Doordarshan)

A love for the Tamil poet

Subramania Bharathi was instilled in us from an early age. In ‘Agnikunjondru kanden’, he writes about finding a tiny spark of fire, hiding it in a hollow in the forest and watching the forest burn down. This idea of igniting a spark seemed to be a recurrent theme in the works of poets and writers in pre-Independence India, and it inspired ordinary people to join the movement. On the other end of the spectrum was Hindi poet Makhanlal Chaturvedi’s 1921 poem ‘Pushp ki Abhilasha’. It was written from the perspective of a flower that desires to be plucked and placed on the path trodden by the brave who fought

for the motherland. The verses tugged at the heartstrings. Decades later, in 1988, the Lok Seva Sanchar Nigam created a song that reinforced the concept of unity in diversity – ‘Mile sur mera tumhara’, with lyrics in 14 languages, for the youth of the time. It was composed by Ashok Patki and arranged by Louis Banks, and featured well-known names from the field of arts such as vocalists M. Balamuralikrishna, Pt. Bhimsen Joshi, Lata Mangeshkar and Kavita Krishnamurthy, besides film stars such as Amitabh Bachchan, Sharmila Tagore and Waheeda Rehman. The very next year came a 13-minute video

‘Desh Raag’, where musicians and dancers celebrated the cultural plurality and shared national identity through an ancient Hindustani raag. In 1997, as India rang in 50 years of Independence, composer A.R. Rahman and filmmaker Bharat Bala teamed up for a new version of ‘Vande Mataram’. ‘Maa tuije salaam’, a track from the album, soon became the anthem of youngsters. Pakistani singer Nusrat Fateh Ali Khan’s ‘Gurus of Peace’, from the album, also became popular. Written by Mehboob, Tim Cody and Dinesh Kapoor, the lyrics went thus: “Boundaries have been drawn on land, but don’t raise a wall between hearts.” Today, in a deeply cynical world, that age of innocence seems like a distant dream. As nostalgic as this all is, one truly wishes we went back to simpler times where we celebrated commonalities instead of highlighting differences. Bharathi would agree. After all, in his song, ‘Thaayin manikodi paarere’, he asks us to celebrate the diversity of a country that is home to people from varied cultural backgrounds and languages, linked by one common flag.

The first dawn of Independence



I was four then and too young to grasp the historical significance of the day. My father, K.G. Subramanian, a Congressman and filmmaker, had hosted a large feast. Our house in Santhome, spread over 36 acres, was teeming with people: freedom fighters, relatives, artistes and friends. We were used to having guests every day, but that gathering remains etched in my memory. Looking back now, I can imagine the emotions that swept across the nation. One memory stands out clearly: my father asking my mother to compose a special song for me. Standing before the guests, I sang, ‘Gandhi thatha solli paadu paapa...’ What remains with me is not so much the song itself as the atmosphere that surrounded it. The house was filled with people from different walks of life, all united by a sense of joy, relief and hope for the future.

PADMA SUBRAHMANYAM



I do not particularly like being reminded of that day, because, in many ways, I feel we have let ourselves down as a nation. I often wonder how much we have honoured the sacrifices and commitment of those who fought to secure our freedom, and where we are headed today. I say this because the dawn of Independence was ushered in a truly secular spirit. In Tirupunithura, where I lived, songs by Tagore, Bharati, Kumaran Asan and Vallathol echoed through the streets as people across social and economic divides came together, singing and rejoicing as one.

T.V. GOPALAKRISHNAN



I was 12 years old and studying in the third form. I lived with my paternal grandmother on West Main Street in Thanjavur and attended mridangam lessons twice a day at the home of my guru, the renowned mridangam vidwan Thanjavur Vaidyanatha Iyer, on Pandamanickapa Street. That day, the lanes were so crowded that it was nearly impossible to walk through them. I am 90 and don’t think I have ever witnessed such an outpouring of joy. People dressed in white khadi were all over, singing ‘Vande Mataram’ as they marched. As a teenager, I was excited and joined them in song, sharing in the jubilation of a nation celebrating its newfound freedom.

UMAYALPURAM SIVARAMAN

CULTURE BRIEFS

Onam special line up

Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Chennai Kendra, celebrates Onam with a special five-day festival titled ‘Bhavanonam’ at its Mylapore and Kilpauk venues. It will be held from August 17 to 23, 6.30 p.m. The celebrations will bring to life Kerala’s rich cultural heritage, featuring traditional art forms. From Kathakali, short plays in Malayalam and musical ensemble to Thiruvathirakali, Mudiyyattam, Panchari Melam, Ottanthulal and Onappattu performances, the festival will offer a colourful display of the folk tradition of the state. Details of the programmes (non-ticketed) to take place at Bhavan’s Mylapore venue are: August 17: ‘Naragasura Vadham (Kathakali).



August 18: Musical ensemble featuring artistes from Kerala. August 20: Malayalam short plays. August 21: ‘Avani’, a Kerala cultural odyssey. The following performances will be featured at Bhavan’s TAG Auditorium, Kilpauk: Panchari Melam; Onappattukal; Thiruvathirakali; Mudiyyattma (folklore); and Ottanthulal. Date and time: August 23, 6.30 p.m.

Independence Day special

Hamsadhwani will feature the following concerts on August 15, 6.15 p.m.: Kalaigalil Ilaya Bharatham series, Desa Bhakthiyum Deiva Bhakthiyum by Vishruthi Girish and Samanvitha Sasidharan. They will be accompanied by Srikrishnan Subramanian, Adarsh Devarajan and Hari Kishore. August 16, 6.15 p.m.: Kruthi Vittal with V.V.S. Murari (violin), Sai Giridhar (mridangam) and Sunil Kumar (kanjira). Venue: Youth Hostel, Adyar.



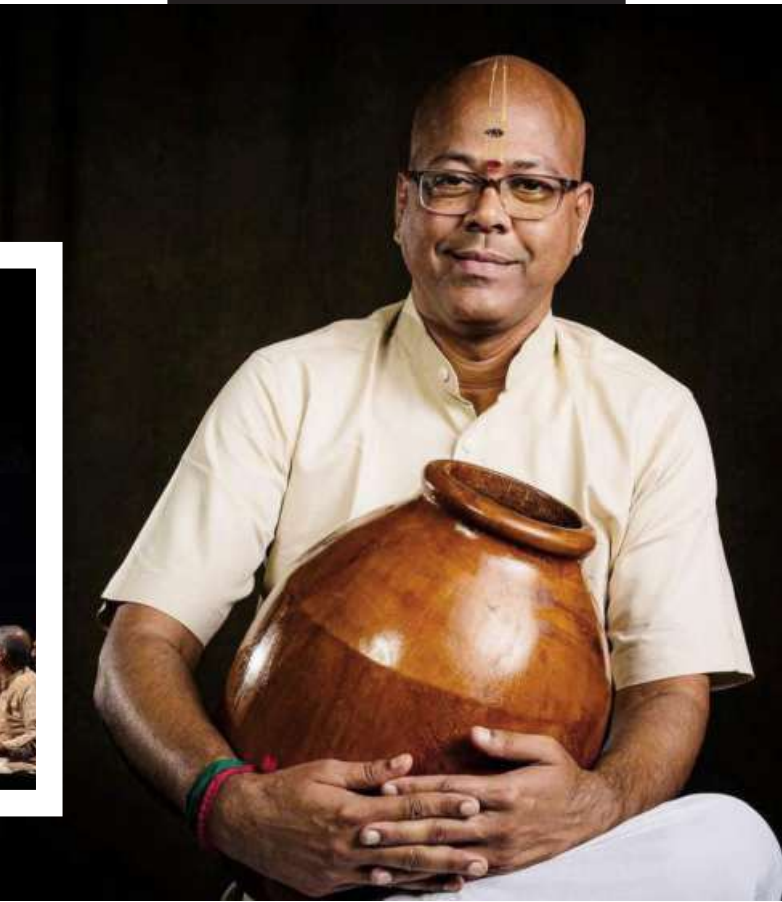
Celebrating Dikshitar’s Navavaranamams

Among the most celebrated works of Muthuswami Dikshitar, the *Kamalamba Navavarana Kirtanams* occupy a unique place in the Carnatic repertoire. Composed around the nine *avarana* (enclosures) of the Sri Chakra, the cycle offers a glimpse into the composer’s mastery of varied ragas, intricate rhythmic structures and distinctive musical treatment. Its detailed notation in Subbarama Dikshitar’s *Sangita Sampradaya Pradarshini* also provides an invaluable window into the musical tradition through which these masterpieces have been preserved and transmitted. Chennai-based Guruguhaamrta, helmed by Carnatic vocalist G. Ravikiran, brings this remarkable work to the fore on August 15, with T.M. Krishna and his disciples presenting the complete *Kamalamba Navavarana Kirtanams* as notated in the

Sangita Sampradaya Pradarshini. They will be accompanied by Charulatha Chandrashekar on the veena and K. Arun Prakash on the mridangam. Through such initiatives, Guruguhaamrta seeks to deepen the understanding and appreciation of Dikshitar’s music among students and musikas. The presentation offers an opportunity to experience these compositions not merely as individual kritis, but as a cohesive musical journey through the nine enclosures of the Sri Chakra. The concert is non-ticketed. Seating from 5 p.m. and on first-cum-first-served basis. For more details send a mail to guruguhaamrta@gmail.com



Innovative Guruprasad with the ‘One G’; at T.M. Krishna’s Sangita Kalanidhi concert in 2024 at The Music Academy; and the clay ghatam. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT & M. SRINATH



N.C. Srinivasaraghavan

The ghatam, one of the oldest percussion instruments in the Carnatic tradition, is a clay pot capable of producing a remarkable range of sounds through strokes delivered across its surface. Despite its musical richness, the traditional instrument has inherent limitations. Made from fired clay, traditional ghatams can weigh as much as 10-12 kg and are fragile. Each piece is crafted to a specific pitch that, while allowing minor adjustments, cannot be tuned across multiple srutis.

To address these limitations, ghatam vidwan N. Guruprasad has developed the ONE G (One Ghatam), a wooden instrument that reimagines the classical percussion instrument while retaining its distinctive tonal character. Weighing anywhere between three to four kilograms, the ONE G is lighter and more durable compared to its clay counterpart. It can also be fine-tuned to different srutis using a guitar processor with customised EQ patches, allowing artistes to quickly match any pitch without carrying multiple ghatams.

Raised in a family steeped in Carnatic music, Guruprasad trained under his father, K.

The ghatam, recrafted

N. Guruprasad’s ‘One G’ gives the clay ghatam a wooden makeover

Nagaraja Rao, before continuing his tutelage under ghatam maestro Vikku Vinayakram and later under V. Suresh and Madurai T. Srinivasan. Today, he performs internationally and mentors students across six continents. His career has taken him to prestigious venues such as the Kennedy Center in Washington, the Lincoln Center in New York and The Oval in England for the *Incredible India* festival, as well as the Johannesburg Philharmonic Orchestra.

The idea for ONE G evolved after years of experimentation, says Guruprasad. In 2008, he first

attempted to create a fibre ghatam, fitted with trigger pads that played back studio-recorded samples of his strokes. The aim was to retain the familiar playing technique while using technology to overcome some of the limitations. However, the system reproduced only his recorded *naadam* rather than the unique tonal character of the artiste playing it. After nearly two years, he abandoned the idea and began exploring an acoustic alternative.

Guruprasad next wanted to create a ghatam that would



produce the performer’s distinct sound, much like an electric violin, where the instrument’s vibrations are captured by pick-ups rather than reproduced through pre-recorded samples. He decided to make a ghatam with wood. “Unlike the mridangam, kanjira or even the veena, where wood primarily serves as a supporting structure, the wooden shell itself becomes the sounding body of ONE G,” he explains. Turning the idea into a viable instrument proved to be a challenge, taking nearly 16 years of research, experimentation and failures. One of the biggest challenges was finding craftsmen willing to carve a hollow instrument from a single block of wood. The density and grain also vary across the trunk, making the selection of wood itself critical.

Beginning with Chittoor-based artisan Arunachalam, Guruprasad later collaborated with craftsmen Kuppusamy Aachar and, subsequently, Sundaramurthy Aachar, whose expertise helped refine the instrument. Arriving at the ideal dimensions, neck profile and wall thickness was equally important. Unlike a clay ghatam, whose pitch is largely determined during the firing process, a wooden ghatam depends on precise wall thickness during carving. Even a slight variation can render it unsuitable for performance, he states.

Drawing on the technical inputs of his colleagues – Neyveli Radhakrishnan and N. Ramakrishnan, violinist Sayee Rakshith, and sound engineers Chandramouli and Raja Subramaniam – Guruprasad took on the project’s most formidable task: recreating the unique acoustic character of the clay ghatam. Because clay is largely isotropic, vibrations propagate more evenly through it. Wood, by contrast, is anisotropic, with its grain affecting the speed and direction of sound transmission. The ONE G therefore uses a standard ghatam pick-up connected to a digital signal processor (DSP), where customised equalisation and

pitch-shift settings recreate the tonal response of a clay ghatam. “With the help of violinist Sayee Rakshith, we analysed the frequency spectrum of a traditional clay ghatam, including its fundamental frequency and resonant overtones, and developed custom EQ patches to recreate its tonal character as closely as possible,” shares Guruprasad. The system also enables features such as a clearly resonant lower-octave shadjam and the ability to produce dual pitches. Leading ghatam artistes, including Guruprasad’s gurus Vikku Vinayakram and V. Suresh, as well as peers Ghatam Karthick and G. Chandrasekara Sharma, evaluated the new instrument and observed that the ONE G is able to closely replicate the tonal qualities of a traditional clay ghatam.

The instrument also requires artistes to adapt their playing approach. In performance, a pick-up and an external microphone work together – the pick-up captures the higher frequencies, while the microphone reinforces the bass and acoustic character. It also minimises the need to play forcefully for projection. For touring musicians, another advantage is its relative resistance to changes in weather. It requires little maintenance, beyond occasional polishing and is less vulnerable to breakage. Guruprasad, however, stresses that the ONE G is not intended to replace the traditional instrument. “It should co-exist with the traditional clay ghatam,” he feels.

The ONE G has so far been tested in concerts and through trial recordings. Guruprasad believes its potential extends beyond Carnatic music, particularly to fusion and film music, where multiple octaves and advanced electronic processing can be fully explored. Carnatic vocalist Vignesh Ishwar led the patent process, coordinating the paperwork and working with the patent attorney, with funding support from the Sumanasa Foundation, an arts-focused non-profit founded by Carnatic vocalist T.M. Krishna in 2005.

ONE G will be launched on August 19 (6 p.m.) at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Myslapore.



Vignesh Ishwar with R.K. Shriramkumar (violin), Praveen Sparsh (mridangam) and Anirudh Athreya (kanjira). PHOTO: B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Cohesive narrative

An expansive Mukhari, sensitive accompaniment and a well-curated repertoire marked Vignesh Ishwar’s concert

Aishwarya Raghunathan

The Kalyani Menon Foundation recently organised Vignesh Ishwar’s concert at The Music Academy’s Kasturi Srinivasan Hall to mark the fifth death anniversary of well-known singer Kalyani Menon. R.K. Shriramkumar was on the violin, Praveen Sparsh on the mridangam and Anirudh Athreya on the kanjira.. The concert opened on an

energetic note with Swati Tirunal’s ‘Sri kumaranagaralaye’ in Atana. The mood then shifted with the rendition of Dikshitar’s ‘Sri matrubhutam’, a chowka kala composition in Kannada. The niraval at ‘Vasudeva mahitam’ was steeped in bhava and seamlessly seagued into kalpanaswaras at ‘Suvasita nava’ in madhyama kala. Shriramkumar’s violin opened the next piece, Marimutha Pillai’s ‘Kaalai thooki ninradum’, in Yadukula Kamboji, with an alapana that

maintained a calm and steady mood. The concert regained its vibrancy with the rapid brigas of Tyagaraja’s ‘Nenarunchinanu’.

The centrepiece of the concert was an elaborate Mukhari alapana, which transitioned smoothly into Tyagaraja’s ‘Kaarubaru seyur’ . Vignesh displayed remarkable breath control during a sustained phrase at ‘Sakethanagari’, and Shriramkumar stepped in with the opening word of the charanam, ‘Nelaku’, marking a moment of impressive coordination between the vocalist and the violinist. The niraval at ‘Saadi tyagaraja’ and the kalpanaswaras that followed, rendered in two kalamas, moved steadily towards the tani avartanam featuring Praveen Sparsh and Anirudh

Athreya. The thani highlighted the contrasting approaches of the two percussionists. While Praveen’s mridangam leaned towards mathematical complexity, Anirudh’s kanjira favoured groove and aesthetic appeal. Yet, the two complemented rather than competing with each other – their synergy shaping the thani into a wholesome experience for the listener.

A subtle thread tied the entire concert together: every piece presented belonged to the suddha madhyama janya family, a coherence that was more felt than announced. It resurfaced in the virutham, which featured verses from Adi Shankarar’s ‘Matrupanchakam’ and traversed Mayamalavagowla, Sahana and Ahiri. The concert then transitioned into Syama Sastri’s lyrically intense ‘Maayamma yanine’, a piece that left Shriramkumar visibly moved.

The final stretch moved away from the weightier centre of the concert. ‘Janaki ramana’ in Kapi introduced a lighter hue, followed by Namdev’s abhang ‘Maaje maher pandari’ – an apt choice for the month of Ashada. Bhadrachala Ramadas’s ‘Ramachandraya janaka’ brought the concert to a close.

Thoughtful choices

Prasanna Venkataramanan presented a blend of familiar and rare kritis



Prasanna with Shertalai Ananthakrishnan (mridangam), Tiruchi Krishnaswamy (ghatam), Shobhana (tanpura) and R. Raghul (violin) PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

G. Swaminathan

Thoughtful programming often sets apart a concert, and vocalist Prasanna Venkataramanan demonstrated this at Kedaram’s 11th anniversary music series. Beginning with the rarely heard Kanada varnam by Tiruvottiyur Tyagayya and concluding with the Darbari Kanada thillana by Thanjavur Kalyanaraman, the lineup showed the vocalist’s penchant for planning. Prasanna was accompanied by R. Raghul on the violin, Shertalai Ananthakrishnan on the mridangam, Tiruchi Krishnaswamy on the ghatam and Shobhana on tambura.

Tyagaraja’s ‘Sarasiruhanana ramayya’ in Mukhari, with the pallavi embellished by swarakalpana, was followed by Dikshitar’s ‘Shankha Chakra Gadapanim’ in Poornachandrika, which had swarakalpana in the charanam line, ‘Kujati graha vihitam’. Prasanna then took up Ritigowla for elaboration, bringing out the raga’s evocative contours. The exposition led to Tyagaraja’s ‘Nannu vidachi

kadalakura’. An enjoyable Hamsanadam alapana, marked by well-measured brigas and karvais, prefaced Oothukadu Venkata Kavi’s popular ‘Kalyanarama’. Another emotionally charged composition was Syama Sastri’s ‘Mayamma’ in Ahiri.

For the main piece, Prasanna chose Harikamboji, dwelling effectively on its upper-register sancharas. He followed it with Papanasam Sivan’s ‘Kamala padamalarinai maravathe’, taking up ‘Thirumal marugane saravana bhavane’ for niraval and swaraprasthara. The swaras were crafted with imagination and restraint, avoiding needless excess. The rarely heard ‘Smara sundaranguni sarievware’ in Paras by Dharmapuri Subbaraya Iyer was the penultimate piece.

R. Raghul proved an able accompanist, matching the vocalist with sensitivity while bringing his own creativity to the raga, niraval and swara passages.

Shertalai Ananthakrishnan and Trichi Krishnaswamy lent spirited support, their camaraderie evident in a well-crafted tani avartanam.

HCL concert

The Music Academy will feature K Aathreyee Krishnaa’s vocal concert on August 17, 6 p.m. at the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall. She will be accompanied by Sahana Sreeram (violin) and Guruvayoor Lakshman (mridangam).



Cult comedy returns

Kathadi Ramamurthy’s Stage Creations drama troupe, now in its 60th year, will stage its evergreen cult comedy *Ayya Amma Amamma*. Written by Crazy Mohan, the play returns to the stage after a long hiatus. A trimmed version of the play will be staged on August 14 at Bappalal Bhawan, Thiruvannamipur, which is open to all; while two ticketed shows will be staged on August 16 at Bengal Association and August 22 for Hamsadhwani.



Memorial concert

Sarvani Sangeetha Sabha Trust will host a four-hour concert on August 16, from 4.15 p.m. at Ragasudha Hall, Myslapore. Artistes to perform are: Bangalore Brothers (vocal) with Bombay R. Madhavan (violin), Shertalai R. Anantakrishnan (mridangam) and D.V. Venkatasubramanian (ghatam). The concert is organised in memory of singer S. Janaki.



Gayathri Girish; Swetha Prachande; Sarveshan; Rithvik Raja; Harinie Jeevitha and Amritha Murali.
PHOTO: S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

Cosmos in motion

Natyarangam’s Pancha Bhootha Bharatham festival, featuring five musicians and five dancers, begins today

Thematic festivals have, over the years, found a special place among rasikas and artistes since they offer newer ways to view and explore familiar subjects. It is from this perspective that Natyarangam has been, for the past 27 years, curating the annual Bharatham festival. It gives dancers the freedom to work around a chosen theme and present an entire performance. Most often their efforts are supported by research scholar and professional musicians.

This year, Natyarangam will focus on Pancha Bhootham, which will bring together Bharatanatyam dancers, Carnatic musicians and research scholar Dr. Sudha Seshayyan to present choreographic pieces on the five elements – *Prithvi* (Earth), *Apah* (Water), *Agni* (Fire), *Vayu* (Air) and *Akasa* (Sky).

Talking about working on *Apah* (water) dancer Shweta Prachande says, “The Thales philosophy helps me understand how water, which



(Clockwise from above) Dr. Sudha Seshayyan; Navia Natarajan; Christopher Gurusamy; Vignesh Ishwar and Aishwarya Vidhya Raghunath.

is crucial for sustenance, assumes different forms as solid, liquid and vapour. While I did a deep dive into this element, I realised how closely it connects to our life’s journey”.

Carnatic musician Rithvik

Raja, who is working with wife Shweta on the concept says, “More than simply representing water through sound, it was fascinating to see how music and movement seamlessly come together.”

Dancer K. Sarveshan, who presents *Prithvi*, shares that the creative process helped him reimagine the Pancha Boothas for the contemporary audience. “Collaborating with senior vocalist Amritha Murali has been an incredibly enriching and rewarding journey.”

Dancer Navia Natarajan, describes it as an introspective journey. Through her performance she will highlight how *Agni* (fire) revealed itself though its many layers, making her understand better its significance.

The festival will reiterate the interconnectedness between art and Nature.

The line up
Pancha Bhootha Bharatham will be held from August 14 to 18, 6.15 p.m., at Narada Gana Sabha.

August 14: K. Sarveshan (dancer) with Amritha Murali (vocalist) presents *Prithvi* (Earth).

August 15: Shweta Prachande with Rithvik Raja will perform *Apah* (Water).

August 16: Navia Natarajan (dancer) and Aishwarya Vidhya Raghunath’s performance is themed on *Agni* (Fire).

August 17: Christopher Gurusamy (dancer) and Vignesh Ishwar — *Vayu* (Air).

August 18: Dancer Harinie Jeevitha and musician Gayathri Girish will present *Akasa* (Sky).

Artiste of two realms

After the premiere of *Thing With Feathers*, his latest production for Aadyam Theatre, Rajat Kapoor reflects on moving between theatre and films



New act Rajat Kapoor (below); and with Kumar Shahani and Pt. Birju Maharaj on the sets of *Khayal Gatha* (left). PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Narendra Kusnur

Rajat Kapoor has long made the most of worlds – cinema and theatre. Now, the actor-filmmaker is gearing for the premiere of *The Thing With Feathers*, his latest production for Aadyam Theatre. It was staged at Bal Gandharva Rang Mandir in Mumbai recently.

Asked how he divides his work between films and theatre, and between direction and acting, Rajat Kapoor says, “There is nothing to balance. I just do what comes my way, if I believe in it. But I consider myself a filmmaker first, then a stage director and then an actor.”

He, along with co-writers Rabia Kapoor and Chandrachoor Rai, spent considerable time working on the play.

Says Rajat, “A lot happened between 1900 and 1950 – the two World Wars, the Great Depression, colonial rule in India and the rise of Russia. But this is not a history lesson. Rather, the play explores the lives of ordinary people who lived in that period, mainly in Europe and India.”

It is the fourth production by Aadyam Theatre this year after Vikrant Pawar’s *Ankahi*, Mohit Takalkar’s *Dil Ka Haal Sune Dilwala* and Sheena Khalid’s *Belly of the Beast*. It also marks Rajat’s second collaboration with Aadyam, a decade after his 2016 adaptation of William Shakespeare’s *As You Like It* - titled *I Don’t Like It, As You Like It*.

“Aadyam is doing a great job by creating opportunities for the theatre community. By producing five plays every year, and along with META



(Mahindra Excellence in Theatre Awards), it has played a vital role in taking theatre to bigger venues.”

According to Rajat, theatre has seen a revival in the past 10 years. “Barring the lockdown years, there has been a growth in audience, which has been a great motivation for theatre practitioners.”

Besides *As You Like It*, Rajat has also directed plays based on Shakespeare’s *Macbeth* (*What’s Done Is Done*) and *King Lear* (titled *Nothing Like Lear*) as well as Fyodor Dostoevsky’s *The Brothers Karamazov* (*Karamjale Brothers*). He points out that these are not straightforward adaptations. “There’s something about those plays that drew me, but I choose an idea or thread from the original text and make it my own by adding new situations. I believe that even while adapting a work, one can find your voice,” he says.

Born in Delhi, Rajat says he had set his sights on cinema by the time he was 15. He recalls, “There was no specific reason. I guess I just loved films.

Theatre happened when I joined Alliance Française in Delhi, where there was a theatre group.”

After training at the Film and Television Institute of India (FTII), Rajat made his screen debut in Kumar Shahani’s 1989 film *Khayal Gatha*, which was based on Hindustani classical music. He turned director with the film *Private Detective: Two Plus Two Plus One* in 1997. The turning point came four years later with Farhan Akhtar’s *Dil Chahta Hai* and Mira Nair’s *Monsoon Wedding*, which gained him recognition for his performance.

As a filmmaker, Rajat has explored a wide range of themes through films such as *Raghu Romeo*, featuring Vijay Raaz as a waiter in a dance bar; *Mixed Doubles*, about a pair of swinging couples; the black comedy *Mithya*; and *Ankhon Dekhi*, about a person who refuses to accept anything he is told unless he sees it with his own eyes.

Reflecting on choosing unusual stories, Rajat says, “Whether it is a film or a play, I take up subjects that excite me. I’m not here for the marketplace. I have to believe in what I am making.”

Much as he loves both the mediums, Rajat feels that filmmaking has become more difficult in recent years. “Raising money to make a film has become harder. I always keep four or five scripts ready with me, so let’s see when I get the opportunity and resources to make my next film. While I wait, theatre keeps me alive,” he says.

The Thing With Feathers encores at Mumbai’s Jamshed Bhabha Theatre on September 12 and 13; and New Delhi’s Kamani Auditorium on September 26 and 27.

The ensemble cast comprises Vinay Pathak, Mantra, Neil Bhoopalam, Radhika Mehrotra, Waris Ahmed Zaidi, Bhavya Rampal, Chandrachoor Rai, Amit Purohit, Vidushi Chaddha, Bhagyashree Tarke and Aaraha Mukherjee.

Vaishali K.S.

On the Carnatic kutcheri medal, the kanjira is referred to as an *upa pakkavadayam* (secondary supporting instrument). Over the years, however, this modest frame drum has moved beyond its traditional role, finding a place in percussion ensembles and cross-genre collaborations. Its practitioners are increasingly rediscovering the instrument’s versatility, experimenting the sonic possibilities. This spirit of exploration was evident at Kashi Damaru, a Hindustani music-based percussion presentation conceived by Jagadeesh Kurthkoti. It was performed as part of the Samatva Sambhrama Music Festival, organised by kanjira artiste Guruprasanna, at Bengaluru’s Chowdiah Memorial Hall.

Kashi Damaru, the name evoked the drum’s association with the Shiv Nagari (Kashi), was conceived around the concepts of veda, naada, bhava, swara, laya and tala. The ensemble, led by Jagadeesh, wove intricate rhythmic patterns. The presentation also featured *konnakol*, the Carnatic art of vocalising rhythmic syllables, by Somashekhar Jois, with the spoken patterns subsequently played on the instruments.

The first segment, ‘Veda Nadaatmaka Yajna’, opened with a recitation of the Maheshwara Sutra in raag Bairagi Bhairav by Somashekhar Jois and vocalist Ganesh Desai. Jagadeesh set the



On the beat Jagadeesh Kurthkoti with the Kashi Damaru ensemble at the Samatva Sambhrama Music Festival in Bengaluru. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Vallabha ashtaka, ‘Namo Bhootanatham’ – a composition by Adi Shankaracharya in raga Shree by Ramesh and Ganesh. This segment, in tisra jati Teen taal, concluded with a tani avartanam that was rounded off with a grand chakradhar ending in tisra jati. These advanced variations, in which intricate mathematical calculations and strategically placed gaps were employed to achieve the final resolution on the *sam*, were negotiated with finesse by the percussionists and articulated with clarity and speed in Somashekhar’s konnakol.

The fourth segment commenced with the rendition of ‘Rudrashtaka’, a composition by Tulsidas in raag Madhukauns, by Ganesh and Ramesh. This was set to khanda jati and was followed by another vibrant tani avartanam that culminated in chakradhar.

The final segment took off on a majestic note with Sadashiva stotra in raag Darbari Kanada, commencing with a prefatory, intricate nom-tom tarana pattern before the stotra. The grand finale was the ‘Kashi damaru paran chakradhar’ executed with elan by the percussionists.

The performance underscored the spiritual moorings of Indian music and its deep links with ancient literature,

Rhythms of Rudra

Kashi Damaru, an ensemble of 10 artistes led by Jagadeesh Kurthkoti, traced Indian music’s spiritual heartbeat through percussion

tone with an *uthan* on the tabla, followed by Vinod Shyam Anoor on the damaru. Ganesh then rendered the shloka ‘Karpuragaaram karunavataram’, while also providing *lehra* accompaniment on the samvadini and sounding the customary conch. The rhythmic journey gathered momentum with a finely structured passage, executed with admirably by Jagadeesh and Manish Tamboskar

on the tabla and pakhawaj. The vedic verses, invoking the five faces of ‘Panchamukha Rudra’ – Sadyojata, Vamadeva, Aghora, Tryambaka and Tatpurusha – were articulated as vocal incantations by incorporating the ‘chand kavit’ of natya by Sri Suryakiran and Sri Sanke. Simultaneously, Jagadeesh and Manish came up with an impressive rendition of Mahamrityunjay Paran, Damaru

Paran and Gat Chakradhar – thereby, creating an electrically-charged atmosphere. The improvisations on raag Bairagi by Deepak Paramashivan on the sarangi and Niranjana Hegde on the flute, in this segment, were noteworthy. Vocalist, Ramesh Kulkarni also rendered a riveting Shiva stuti – ‘Ganga taranga ramaniya jataakalapam’.

Jagadeesh opened the second segment ‘Naadaprasana’ – a veritable musical worship – with a solo *uthan* on the tabla for a composition in raag Bahar: ‘Deem deem dam damaru baaje’ in Teen taal sung by vocalists Ganesh and Ramesh Kulkarni.

In this phase, there was a tani avartanam during which chatushra jati Teen taal was played by all the percussionists – Jagadeesh Kurthkoti (tabla), Manish Tamboskar (pakhawaj), Shyam Anoor (mridangam), Somashekhar (konnakol) and Gopi Shrivani Tirumale (chanda and morching) – creating rhythmic patterns, which were a blend of syncopation and micro-timing.

The third segment started with a stately rendition of Parvathi



The band stole the spotlight at FIFA World Cup final halftime show.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT & GETTY IMAGES

The band stole the spotlight at FIFA World Cup final halftime show. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT & GETTY IMAGES

PHOTOS: SPECIAL
ARRANGEMENT &
GETTY IMAGES

Rachel Rhine

In March 2026, at the Oscars, songwriter EJAE accepted the award for Best Original Song as part of the songwriting team behind 'Golden', the hit song from the film *KPop Demon Hunters* and the first K-pop song to win the award. Speaking to the room, she recalled how people had once mocked her for pursuing the genre. That night, nobody in the room doubted K-pop's global appeal or its place on the biggest stage.

But four and a half months later, all seven members of BTS posted on Instagram that they would not submit an entry to the Grammys this year. This came despite their album *ARIRANG* topping the Billboard 200, the Circle Album Chart, Oricon, and the British and German album charts, while its lead single, 'SWIM', had given them a seventh No. 1 on the Billboard Hot 100. BTS declined to submit anyway, saying they hoped music could be heard and loved without being divided by region or language.

BTS' Grammy *Boycott*

The K-pop band will skip the 2027 awards, objecting to the new Asian Pop category

What changed between March and July was the introduction of a new category. On June 16, the Recording Academy, which presents the Grammys, and is separate from the Academy that presents the Oscars, announced the Best Asian Pop Music Performance category for the 2027 Grammys, stipulating that qualifying recordings must make meaningful use of an Asian language; entirely English-language recordings are not

eligible. 'SWIM', sung mostly in English, would therefore not have qualified for the category that some had speculated was created with BTS in mind.

The band, one of the most globally influential acts, was unwilling to accept the new categorisation and announced that it would not submit its music for Grammy consideration. Recording Academy CEO Harvey Mason Jr., expressing his disappointment over

their decision, defended the new category in a statement. “The Asian Pop category was created to celebrate the depth, diversity and extraordinary growth of pop artistry coming out of Asia. More categories mean more artists’ work is recognised. It’s never to divide, but to expand who is recognised by our 15,000 Grammy voters,” he said.

"I also want to be clear: submitting music in a genre category such as Asian Pop or Jazz does not exclude an artiste from also submitting and being considered in the General Field categories," he added.

BTS' position has brought a decade-long conversation to the



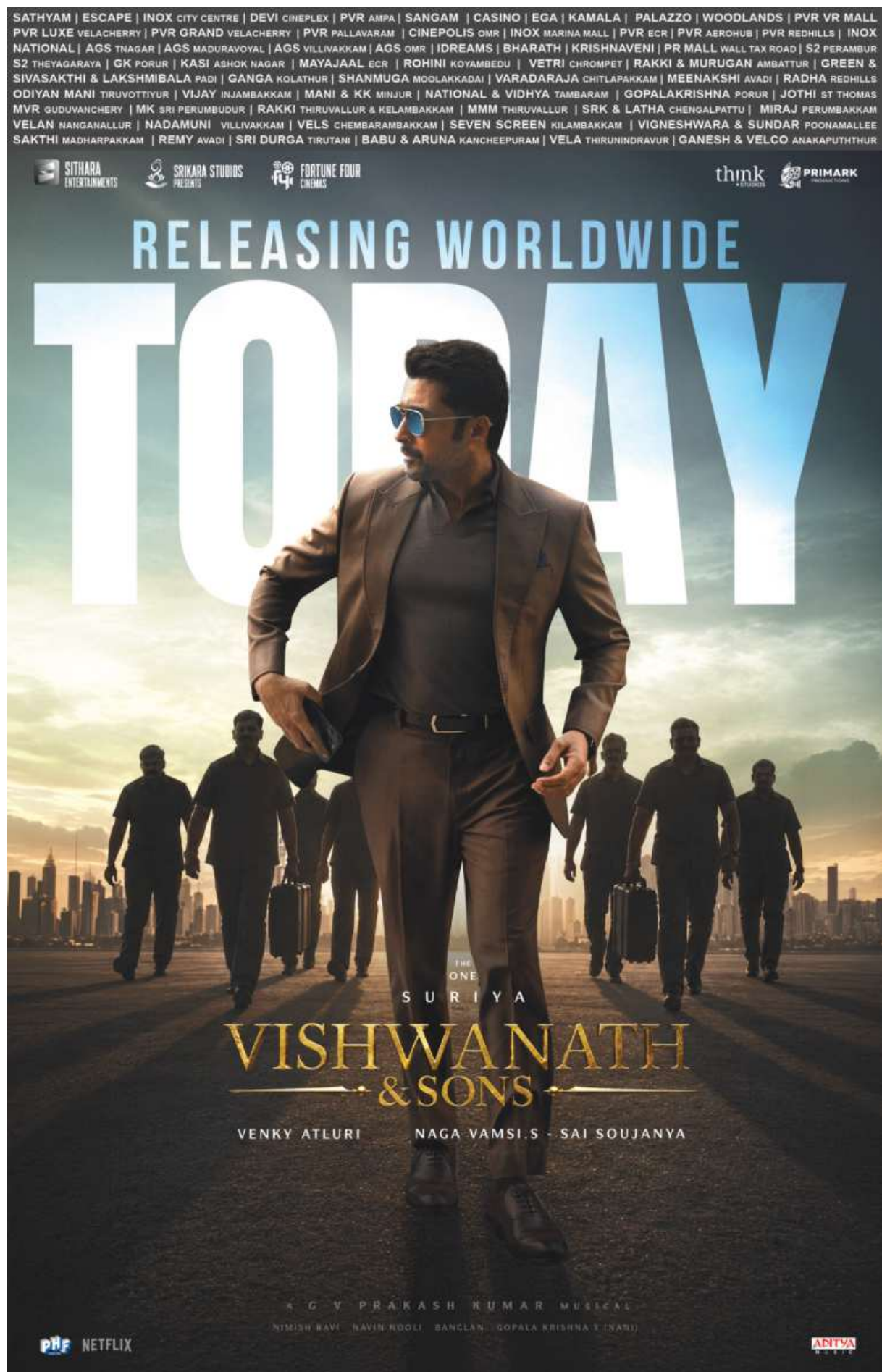
fore — one that has been heard sometimes aloud and often quietly, as artists have spoken of feeling overlooked and restricted. It also raises a larger question: if music transcends language and culture, why does one of the world's biggest music institutions feel compelled to create categories so closely tied to geography?

This is not an argument against every category of its kind. The Latin field has run since 1975 and built careers the general field would never have. Best African Music Performance, introduced in 2024, gave Tyla a Grammy she was not otherwise going to win. But artists have, over the years, expressed concerns that categories such as Urban, R&B, Rap and Country have kept them outside the mainstream pop and limited their opportunities for wider recognition. Now, even a BTS win could be met with a dismissive, “What’s the big deal? It’s only in the Asian category.”

The new label has its own challenges. The Latin category, for instance, has a relatively clear linguistic base, with Spanish and Portuguese sharing Latin roots. Asian pop, on the other hand, spans a huge geographical expanse, encompassing vastly different cultures, musical traditions and languages. The question, then, is what exactly makes up an Asian pop sound?

The Recording Academy has stood here before, and it knows it. In 2020, it renamed Best World Music Album as Best Global Music Album, acknowledging that the term 'world music' carried connotations of colonialism, folk and non-American music. Artists had also described the category as a box that was difficult to climb out of. Six years after acknowledging the problem, the Recording Academy has built another one.

Whoever wins in February 2027 will deserve it. BTS have not refused a trophy; they have only questioned the premise behind the category. EJAE was made fun of for liking K-pop, but this move seems to reinforce the same idea – that music from a specific part of the world should not come with that tag. Grammy should know Asia is a continent, not a genre.





The baton meets Beethoven

Ahead of his India debut with the SOI, young Alessandro Bonato speaks about collaboration and the art of conducting

Narendra Kusnur

At 31, Alessandro Bonato has earned renown as one of Italy's most promising young conductors. Besides conducting the Haydn Orchestra of Bolzano and Trento, he has collaborated with other orchestras and soloists too. "My approach does not change with the orchestra I conduct. I prioritise preparation and respect the musicians I work with," he says. The Verona-born musician is now looking forward to his debut concerts in India – on August 26 and 30 – where he will conduct the Symphony Orchestra of India (SOI). Presented by the National Centre for the Performing Arts (NCPA), the concerts are a part of the Autumn Season 2026. British maestro Martyn Brabbins, who took over as the chief conductor of SOI earlier this year, will lead the two concerts.

The season also marks 20 years of SOI. Alessandro says, he is delighted to share the stage with the musicians in a country that is new to him and eager to discover. "Music is something we create together and everyone has to give their best in order to achieve the common goal – to bring the scores we perform to life in the best possible way," he adds. Alessandro's August 26 concert line-up includes compositions by Italian genius Gioachino Rossini, besides German legend Ludwig Van Beethoven's Violin Concerto, featuring violinist Francesca Dego. On August 30, the programme features Rossini's *Guillaume Tell Overture*, Felix Mendelssohn's Symphony No 4, Beethoven's Symphony No 8 and Pyotr Tchaikovsky's *1812 Overture*. According to Alessandro, the programme includes two major compositions by Beethoven because 2027 will mark his 200th

death anniversary. He says, "I have conducted the Violin Concerto many times, but never with Francesca. I know her by reputation and am absolutely delighted to have an opportunity to collaborate with her." The other composer to feature prominently is Rossini. Alessandro explains, "Ever since I played at the Rossini Opera Festival in Pesaro, Italy, at age 23, I have lived Rossini's music to the fullest, breathing the atmosphere of the festival and of the foundation which oversees all the critical editions of his works. We will perform two of the most beautiful overtures Rossini ever wrote – *La gazza ladr* and *Guillaume Tell* – his last extraordinary opera. One of the challenges of Rossini's music is its dynamics, in particular, the famous 'Rossinian crescendo', which has to be carefully balanced and calibrated." Though he started by learning violin and composition, Alessandro's dream was to become a conductor.

According to him, a conductor is not just someone who "puts the musicians of an orchestra together and keeps time, but a motivator and a guide, who must understand the people in front of him and help them give their best. He must create a shared vision to achieve the best possible result. And he has to study a great deal in order to understand the scores in depth." Though he has conducted most of his concerts across Europe, Alessandro made his debut in Muscat, Oman. "I conducted Mozart's *The Magic Flute* with the local orchestra. I was 20 and it was my first experience abroad. I returned in 2022 with Rossini's *La Cambiale di Matrimonio*. Although Arab audiences do not have a western musical tradition, they do have a rooted popular music culture."

Alessandro has also conducted in Japan and will be returning there in September. He says, "The orchestras are fantastic and audiences, enthusiastic." Having conducted both symphonic music and opera in equal measure, Bonato says there are no fundamental musical differences between the two formats, however, there are structural differences. In opera, there are singers with specific needs that the conductor must recognise and respect. Conducting technique is also slightly different and must accommodate the singers' breathing." Bonato hopes to return to explore India more deeply. He says, "I particularly want to learn about and experience its great centuries-old spiritual tradition."

Split by a line

Playwright Syed Asghar Wajahat on the unresolved trauma of the Partition



Border story From the newly released film *Batwara 1947*, based on the celebrated Hindi play *Jis Lahore Nai Vekhya*, *O Jamyai Nai*. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Anuj Kumar

This Independence Day, Syed Asghar Wajahat's celebrated Hindi play *Jis Lahore Nai Vekhya*, *O Jamyai Nai* gets a cinematic life as filmmaker Rajkumar Santoshi brings the characters alive in screen adaptation of the same in *Batwara 1947*. As we discovered with the quiet success of *Main Vaapas Aaunga* that the unresolved trauma of the Partition remains one of the most potent and enduring themes of our art. "There has been no discussion in the public domain where Hindus and Muslims shared their grievances. Only politicians across parties have exploited the sentiments. That is why it remains unresolved. The confidence-building must emanate from within the communities," says the Hindi scholar who retired as the head of the Hindi Department of Jamia Millia Islamia. Written in the 1980s, *Jis Lahore...* was first staged by Habib Tanvir and

took the theatre world by storm. Wajahat shares that ever since its first staging in 1989, many filmmakers were keen on securing its rights. "Eventually, Govind Nihalani took the rights. But for the next seven-eight years he could not make the film." Then he came to know Rajkumar Santoshi was eager to make a film on the play. "As Govind was his guru, Santoshi was sure that he would pass on the rights, but he refused. Ultimately, I had to step in and he agreed; but a new issue emerged." Santoshi, had earlier adapted another of Wajahat's play, *Gandhi-Godse-Ek Yudh*, on to the screen and wanted to make *Jis Lahore* too as a mega budgeted film; but the producers were not willing and "pushed him to make a small-budgeted film. Eventually, it was Aamir Khan, who could see the box office potential in offbeat subjects, decided to back the film," says Wajahat. Set during the Partition, *Jis*



Lahore revolves around the Mirzas, a Muslim refugee family migrating from Lucknow to Lahore. They are allocated a sprawling haveli left behind by a Hindu family, only to find an elderly Hindu woman still residing there. She refuses to leave her home and, over time, develops a bond with the Mirzas, much to the chagrin of the fanatics. Wajahat, who grew up on the farms of Fatehpur in Uttar Pradesh before moving to Aligarh Muslim University for education, says Lahore had its own charm and once upon a time, it was one of the biggest centres of education, fashion, and music in the North." Wajahat was moved by the poetry of Nasir Kazmi, who migrated from Ambala and captured the psychological grief of losing one's home in his ghazals. For him, Ambala was everything. '*Ambala ek shehar tha main hun usi mite huye kareene ki roshni* (*Ambala was a city; I am the flickering light of that erased civility*), he wrote. "I also read memoirs of people, some of whom were distant relatives from Fatehpur, forced to shift by circumstance or due to the unwritten orders of the government. I was also inspired by M.S. Sathya's *Garm Hava*, which is about an elderly lady refusing to cross the border." Mai, or the mother, he says, is central to his story and is the unifying factor between the two communities. "Every creative work demands conflict. So I created a fanatic who seeks division in the name of religion. The communalist is offset by a Maulvi who speaks of the true meaning of the holy book. And in between, I slipped in a real-life poet. When he was on his deathbed, Kazmi gave a long interview where he questioned the formation of Pakistan. This blend of four points of view created a space for the play in popular imagination. For Kannada theatre practitioners, Partition is not their lived reality, but I found out they stage it regularly. Human emotions appeal to everybody," says Wajahat.

Annual festival

Shivanugraha Trust presents the annual music and dance series, featuring Rukmini Ramani's music compositions, from August 14 to 16, at Narada Gana Sabha. It will begin with the distribution of prizes to the winners of the music and dance competitions conducted by the trust recently. B. Hemanathan, Deputy Director, Department of Art and Culture, will be the chief guest. The evening programme also includes Adithya Narayanan's vocal concert with VSP Gayatri Sivani (violin) and N.C. Bharadhwaj (mridangam). Time: 6.15 p.m. August 15 (6 p.m.): S.J. Jananiy's vocal performance (at 6 p.m.) with violinist Usha Rajagopalan, mridangist Nellai A. Balaji and kanjira artiste K.R. Sivaramkrishnan accompanying her. The final day will feature performances by the students of Roja Kannan, Srekala Bharath, Nidheesh Kumar and Indu Nidheesh; Padmalakshme Suresh and Radhika Vairavelavan themed on Rukmini Ramani's composition 'Sri Natarajarin Pancha Sabhaigalin Pancharatham.'



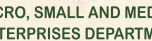
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